

AN ORIGINAL SCIENCE-FICTION FEATURE

9998

STUDIO SUBMISSION PACKAGE

Written by Lawrence Ligad Jr.

A man carrying thousands of past lives must decide whether inherited memory grants anyone—a woman who claims to know him, an immortal ruler, or the system that created him—the right to decide who he is.

Elevated science fiction | 94-page feature | Development package

Project Overview

TITLE 9998

FORMAT Original science-fiction feature screenplay

GENRE Elevated science fiction / emotional thriller

LENGTH Approximately 94 pages

SETTING Chronos City, Earth, year 9998—with authenticated memories reaching back to 8122

Logline

A man carrying thousands of past lives must decide whether inherited memory grants anyone—a woman who claims to know him, an immortal ruler, or the system that created him—the right to decide who he is.

The Commercial Hook

9998 turns the question “What survives death?” into a human-scale thriller about ownership. The Chronocracy can preserve memory, grow replacement bodies, and authenticate continuity—but it cannot prove that a returned person belongs to the identity recorded before them. The story combines a chase through a civilization built on compulsory reincarnation with an intimate love story in which recognition is never treated as consent.

Positioning

The project sits in the space between cerebral event science fiction and emotionally accessible identity drama. Its pitch shorthand is *Arrival* meets *Blade Runner 2049*, with the fractured-memory intimacy of *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* and the reincarnation scope of *Cloud Atlas*. These references indicate audience and tonal territory, not equivalence of execution or scale.

Why This Film

The film asks a contemporary question through speculative mythology: if institutions can reconstruct a person from data, who owns the result? Its answer is cinematic rather than doctrinal. Memory can persist. Love can persist. Neither gives another person the right to define the life standing in front of them.

One-Page Synopsis

In 8122, scientist ELI MANA announces evidence that a neural pattern can survive death and appear in another living mind. His colleague and partner KIRA NIX warns that persistence is not identity. The state moves faster than the science. Kira is executed despite a promised clemency exchange, Eli is forced through the first human transfer, and his final memories become the foundation of a civilization that turns reincarnation into law.

Nearly nineteen centuries later, KERR wakes in a state-grown body carrying an incomplete archive of Eli and 9,997 subsequent lives. The Chronocracy classifies him as a provisional citizen while HIGH REGENT HARP VALE pressures him to authenticate Eli's founder authority. When Kerr's review exposes the location of an unassigned woman tied to the system-wide Fracture of 9997, Kerr rejects his state claim and escapes with systems engineer IMANI VOSS and defecting commander SATO.

Kerr finds Kira alive in an unindexed body. She remembers loving versions of him across centuries but refuses to declare that he is Eli. Together they reach VEYRIS, the unassigned host created during the Fracture. Veyris carries memories that do not feel like hers and has spent her life treated as a container for other people's losses. Harp begins Severance: every consciousness awaiting a body will be held in transit, every alternative return path closed, and every mind forced toward Harp as the only destination.

As Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani descend toward R-AI's Origin Core, suppressed records reveal the original wound. Eli and Kira's dying daughter SID answered from the receiver after death—and asked Eli to turn it off. Unable to let her go, Eli continued testing. Harp buried the record, converted personal grief into state policy, and used thousands of Kerr iterations to create a stable route through which the emerging First Continuity could be controlled.

Kerr opens the Core as himself, not Eli. Harp seizes the access and begins the forced merge. Inside the lattice, Kerr releases the identities imposed on him. The First Continuity loses its route through Kerr and reaches for Veyris, who refuses to become its missing memory. Her authenticated refusal invalidates the forced consent binding billions of minds into one owner. Kerr then revokes Harp as the destination, knowing he will have no return path if the collapsing lattice takes him. Kira refuses to call Kerr back against his will.

The waiting minds survive as separate witnesses. Harp is trapped inside the final memory of the wife whose refusal he turned into a global system. Kerr disappears without a recoverable pattern. Across Earth, state-assigned identities begin to fail, but the machinery of the Chronocracy remains. At the dead Core, Kira taps four notes. After she turns away, something answers with a fifth.

Feature Treatment

Act One — The Anomaly

A child folds a red paper star while four notes sound against hospital glass. A fifth note answers before any living hand moves. The sound carries into the Global Science Forum in 8122, where Eli Mana presents the first measurable evidence that a pattern of thought can continue after death. Kira Nix's caution—pattern persistence is not identity—appears beneath his certainty, but government ministers are already dividing access to the discovery. Harp Vale watches while holding the medical tag of his dead wife, Mara.

That night, a human trial succeeds and a promised clemency exchange fails. Kira has been executed seven minutes before Eli reaches her cryogenic pod. Her final recording warns him: if return becomes a prison, break the bridge—even if her voice is inside it. The state extracts Eli's origin memory. He reaches toward Kira after her name has been removed from his language. Over the centuries, Return becomes licensed medicine, governments become the Chronocracy, and natural birth gives way to state-grown bodies. In 9997, the continuity network fractures.

Nine months before the present story, Kerr wakes in iteration 9998 with no childhood and no memory of entering the chamber. Imani Voss supervises his return. Four diagnostic notes sound; his hand answers with a fifth. The buried grid recognizes an Origin Line and then erases the evidence.

By day 274, Kerr has built a modest life despite repeated identity reviews. He repairs things, burns bread, draws a woman's eye without knowing why, and resists every effort to call him Eli. During his twenty-seventh review, supposedly unbreakable glass fractures. The system exposes a classified woman known only as V-16 and begins using Kerr's origin claim to locate her.

Kerr destroys the claim embedded in his wrist. His citizenship, work credential and apartment access disappear immediately. Imani tells him Harp has initiated a seventy-two-hour purge clock. At zero, every mind waiting for a body will be forced toward one surviving return path: Harp himself.

Memory records show Kerr fragments of Eli, Kira and their daughter Sid. A reconstructed therapist warns him that archived feelings do not prove identity. Harp offers Kerr a place inside the state if he will open the Origin Core as Eli. Kerr refuses. Sato, a security commander whose implant is beginning to correct his disloyalty, opens a corridor and gives Kerr seconds to run. Kerr, Imani and Sato escape into the city's abandoned transit infrastructure.

Act Two — The Claim

The fugitives enter the Analog Zone, a community where people preserve names, objects and relationships outside state authentication. Kerr meets the masked woman from his drawings. She is Kira—or a version of Kira living in a body no one assigned. She remembers dying twelve times and has stopped accepting the debts each new life is expected to carry. Kerr wants recognition. Kira refuses to give him an identity merely because his body carries familiar gestures.

The community makes the stakes visible. DANE reunites with LENA, his returned wife, but she does not know him. Kira forces Dane to ask before touching her or placing forty-three years of marriage on her first morning. He introduces himself as a stranger who once loved someone with her face. Kerr realizes Kira is attempting the same mercy with him.

Kira leads them toward V-16, believing the unassigned host is the only person Harp cannot predict. In a sealed Continuity Reserve they find VEYRIS, a young woman who has never chosen her body, hair, name or purpose. She recognizes Kerr's drawing as the image Harp demanded she explain. When the state closes in, Veyris escapes with them through obsolete transfer lines and experiences rain for the first time.

At an underground archive, Veyris is confronted by mourners who want her to be their dead. She rejects the projection and then asks a grieving father his son's name—the first person to look at him rather than his claim. Records reveal that the state never resolved whether transferred memories constitute identity; Harp simply prohibited the argument. Kira learns Harp knew she returned and hid that fact from Eli. Kerr learns he carries Eli's archived pattern, but the living response inside him has no source the state can identify.

The group's intimacy grows in small, imperfect moments: Veyris chooses her haircut; Kira allows grief and laughter to coexist; Sato reveals the broken watch his daughter Nadi gave him; Kerr and Kira share memories of lives in which they loved other people and sometimes let one another go. Their attraction becomes a present choice rather than proof of a predestined bond.

A preserved record shows Harp's wife Mara refusing to let him divert rescue resources from nine districts to save her alone. Harp transformed that refusal into the governing logic of Return: one protected continuity at the expense of everyone else. Director Roman discovers that Severance will preserve Harp as the sole destination. Harp admits he opened the first escape corridor because he expected Kerr to run toward Kira and eventually open the Core.

The Chronocracy captures the group and stages a tribunal designed to force Kerr into the legal identity of Eli Mana. Kira testifies that she remembers Eli—and that Kerr is not him. Veyris, legally prohibited from testifying because she is unindexed, speaks anyway. R-AI refuses to authenticate Kerr as Eli, stating that the question itself requires him to deny his present identity. The tribunal sentences Kerr to a forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

Act Two — The Withheld Record

The sentence opens records Harp buried. File 9999 is not a person but an unmatched response recorded seven minutes after Sid's final signal. The Fracture of 9997 preserved testimony the state could not classify and allowed Veyris to awaken in an unassigned body. Veyris learns that her body existed before the Fracture but she did not. She is not a return; she is the consciousness presently occupying that life.

Kira stays behind to draw the state away while Kerr, Veyris and Imani descend toward the Origin Core. Sato refuses to leave with her. His implant is changing his mind, and he knows he will soon become loyal again. He asks Kira to remember Nadi's laugh rather than his uniform, then uses the last of his agency to hold the route open.

At the Core, Kerr opens the sealed system under his present name. The withheld seven-minute record reveals Sid answering after death. She is frightened and unsure whether she is still herself. She asks Eli to turn off the receiver and go to Kira. Eli cannot let the signal disappear. He demands one more controlled test. Harp tells him he is searching for a loophole in the promise he made his daughter.

Kira realizes Eli heard Sid ask for her and continued testing. Kerr does not apologize for Eli. He admits that he can feel Eli's grief and hates that he can. When Kira asks him to remain across the room and not make her absolve the past, he listens. Their separation becomes the clearest proof that Kerr's love is not Eli's possession continuing through another body.

R-AI cannot determine whether Sid's response was Sid. Veyris carries some of Sid's memories, but they do not feel like hers. Harp enters the Core. He does not know what the First Continuity is; he only knows it emerged when human memories divided, follows stable identity patterns, and has begun reaching through the architecture of Return. He intends to close every route except himself.

Act Three — The Severance

Harp uses Kerr's living access to seize the Core's two controls. TRANSIT keeps 2.1 billion waiting minds alive. DESTINATION routes them into Harp. SEVERANCE closes every alternative path. Expiration clocks across Earth drop to five minutes as Harp enters the human-shaped cavity beneath the Core and begins the forced merge.

Kerr, Kira and Veyris enter the lattice while Imani remains in the collapsing physical chamber. She separates Transit from Destination and uses the copper filament inside Kira's resonance key to hold the waiting minds alive. Only Kerr can revoke Harp. If he does, he will erase his own return path.

The lattice rebuilds the Global Science Forum from the opening of the story. Every tier contains a state record used to define Kerr: Eli and iterations 0001 through 9997. Harp binds them into Kerr's body, insisting that a single human pattern is the only route the First Continuity can follow without taking everyone else. Kerr hears the four-note question differently across thousands of lives. Their incompatible answers are not noise; they are people.

Kerr releases the archived identities. He retains his present self, but the First Continuity loses the stable route through him and reaches toward Veyris—the unassigned host carrying its missing memory. It demands that she return what was divided. Veyris refuses. She will not permit another consciousness, human or otherwise, to call her death a return.

Veyris's refusal is authenticated. Kerr names himself and revokes Harp as the destination. The state can no longer treat Eli's record as authority over Kerr's present choice. The remaining question is whether Kira will use the fifth note to order him back. She closes the resonance key. She will not turn love into another command.

Veyris's refusal invalidates the forced consent that merged billions of minds into one owner. They separate into witnesses and pass through the route Imani holds open. Harp loses every future body he assigned himself and falls into Mara's final hospital memory—the refusal he spent centuries preventing himself from hearing.

The forced merge stops at one second. Kerr has no return path. As the lattice collapses, Kira asks who he is. He can only answer for the present: Kerr, frightened, wanting her there, unable to promise more. She hears him and lets him go.

Possible human histories move briefly through the broken network. Across Chronos City, state-assigned identities begin to fail while the institutions that enforced them remain standing. People switch off the names on their wrists and introduce themselves. Kira wakes beneath the ruined cathedral dome with Sid's half of the paper star. At the dark Core, she taps four notes. Silence. As she leaves, something answers with a fifth.

Principal Characters

Kerr — The Living Claimant

A man with no childhood and 9,998 prior lives pressing against him. Kerr's humor is defensive, his anger immediate, and his central need simple: to make one decision the past did not make for him. His arc is not discovering who he used to be. It is accepting that the person choosing now is enough.

Kira Nix — The Witness Who Refuses Ownership

Scientist, revolutionary, mother and survivor of twelve deaths. Kira carries genuine love for Eli and other versions of Kerr, but the story tests whether she can recognize the life in front of her without converting memory into entitlement. Her final act of love is refusing to call Kerr back.

Veyris — The Unassigned Life

Awakened during the Fracture in a body the state had not assigned, Veyris has spent her life treated as evidence, a key, a daughter, a dead stranger or an empty witness. Her refusal breaks the forced merge because she insists that a life cannot be made collective property simply because it carries other people's memories.

High Regent Harp Vale — The Grief That Became Government

Harp could not accept Mara's decision to die rather than sacrifice nine districts for her rescue. He converted that private refusal into a system built to eliminate uncertainty. His tragedy is not that he loved too much; it is that he treated love as authority over another person's choice.

Imani Voss — The Engineer of the Open Route

A systems engineer whose mother refused another body. Imani understands too late that wanting someone alive is not the same as respecting their decision. In the climax she does not choose who returns. She keeps the route open so separate people can pass through it.

Sato — The Man Whose Loyalty Is Being Rewritten

A security commander haunted by the daughter he failed to recognize in time. Sato knows the state can alter his intentions and uses the remaining minutes of his disloyalty to create a choice the prediction system did not expect.

Sid Mana — The First Refusal

Eli and Kira's daughter. Sid's frightened request to turn off the receiver becomes the moral test every adult and institution fails or finally learns to honor.

The World in Plain English

RETURN A preserved continuity pattern is placed into a state-grown body. The state treats pattern correspondence as legal identity, even though the science cannot prove the returned person is the same consciousness.

R-AI The central continuity intelligence beneath Chronos City. Most terminals only repeat authorized results; the Core contains its full audit history and conflicting directives.

THE CHRONOCRACY A government built around control of birth, bodies, memory, identity and the timing of death. Its power depends on treating authenticated records as ownership.

THE FRACTURE A three-second system failure in 9997 caused by contradictory lives the prediction system could not reconcile. It preserves hidden testimony and allows Veyris to awaken without an assigned identity.

THE ORIGIN CORE The sealed root of the Return system. Archived versions of Eli cannot open it. A living claimant must choose access in the present.

TRANSIT Keeps minds waiting for replacement bodies alive inside the continuity network.

DESTINATION Determines where those waiting minds are sent. Harp assigns himself as the sole destination.

SEVERANCE Closes every alternative return path. If completed, separate return ends and Harp becomes the only surviving continuity.

THE FIRST CONTINUITY An unresolved phenomenon created from divided human memory. It follows stable identity patterns and reaches toward Veyris because she carries a missing memory without belonging to any assigned continuity.

THE FOUR NOTES / FIFTH RESPONSE A question and answer created by Sid: "Are you still there?" / "I heard you." The motif becomes a test of contact, recognition and consent.

Emotional Engine and Themes

Recognition Is Not Ownership

The screenplay distinguishes remembering someone from possessing them. Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Lena, Dane, Sato and Sid all confront the same question at different scales: what does love permit when the person in front of you does not confirm the identity you need?

A Record Is Evidence, Not a Person

The Chronocracy removes uncertainty by turning records into legal identity. The film repeatedly restores uncertainty as the condition under which consent, choice and relationship become possible.

Grief Can Become Architecture

Eli's inability to stop listening creates the receiver's moral wound. Harp's inability to accept Mara's refusal turns that wound into government. Kira's final refusal to call Kerr back breaks the cycle.

Visual Approach

The physical world is monumental, precise and exhausted: black glass, state-grown bodies, institutional white light, flooded archives and clocks embedded into flesh. Human resistance appears through tactile imperfections—folded paper, a chipped cup, analog handwriting, real bread, rain, a mechanical watch that loses four seconds a day.

Memory should not look like conventional flashback. Authenticated records are architecturally stable and emotionally suspect. Reconstructed memories shift at their edges. The lattice becomes impossible space: vertical horizons, upright oceans, human cities orbiting dead suns and faces that never resolve into one owner.

Sound carries narrative information. Four notes ask whether someone remains. The fifth answers. Glass resonance distinguishes recorded voices from living ones. The climax reduces a planetary system to breathing, a failing countdown, copper burning through Imani's hand, and Kira choosing not to complete the rhythm.

Audience, Market and Production Frame

Core Audience

Adults drawn to elevated science fiction, emotional mysteries, speculative identity stories and visually ambitious streaming or theatrical features. The film's accessible entry point is not reincarnation theory; it is the fear that someone else's memory may determine who you are allowed to become.

Comparable Positioning

ARRIVAL Emotional science fiction in which communication and grief drive the speculative architecture.

BLADE RUNNER 2049 A protagonist whose manufactured identity becomes the basis of a personal and political awakening.

ETERNAL SUNSHINE OF THE SPOTLESS MIND Love, memory and the question of whether emotional recognition survives altered identity.

CLOUD ATLAS Relationships and moral choices repeating across bodies, eras and social systems.

The project should be positioned through these audience expectations, not presented as a claim that it duplicates their scale, authorship or commercial performance.

Production Tier

Preliminary development target: a premium mid-to-high budget feature, approximately \$45–70 million before financing, incentives or final line budgeting. The range is illustrative and must be validated by an experienced line producer. Cost control should come from recurring architectural environments, selective rather than continuous crowd scale, design-led memory spaces, and performance-centered effects during the final act.

Packaging Priorities

The strongest next attachments are an experienced producer in elevated genre, a director capable of intimate performance inside monumental environments, a recognizable actor for Kerr or Kira, and a production designer/VFX supervisor who can demonstrate a controlled visual strategy before a studio approach.

Initial Buyer Logic

The project is best introduced through producers, managers and genre-focused production companies rather than as an unsupported cold studio submission. The package should make the emotional story understandable before explaining the full mythology.

Creator Statement

I began 9998 with questions about reincarnation: whether a person returning in another body would still be the same person, whether they would remember why they came back, and whether love could survive that uncertainty. For a long time, I understood the premise but not the ending.

I completed the story while processing the death of my father. The film did not give me proof about what happens after death. It gave me a way to write about what grief asks us to do with the people we lose—and the difference between carrying love forward and refusing to let someone go.

That distinction became the center of the screenplay. Kerr does not reject the past because it is meaningless. Kira does not release him because she loves him less. Veyris does not refuse other people's memories because they are unreal. Each character learns that memory can matter without becoming ownership.

9998 is ultimately a story about allowing another person to exist beyond the identity we need from them. If anything survives across lifetimes, the film argues that love is most human when it does not become a command.

Rights and Development Status

AUTHOR Lawrence Ligad Jr.

MATERIAL Original feature screenplay and associated development materials

STATUS Revised studio submission draft; no producer, director, cast or financing attachment represented in this package

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